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DRST 0003 – Directed Studies: Philosophy

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Assignment:

Explain the function argument in the Nicomachean Ethics (I.7 1097b22-1098a18). What does Aristotle conclude the human function is? What does he conclude about what the human good is, as a result? Do you find this judgment persuasive?

Title:

*Eudaimonia's* Paradoxical Tension: How Contemplation and Action Shape Aristotle's Good Life

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*Eudaimonia's Paradoxical Tension: How Contemplation and Action Shape Aristotle's Good Life*

P1: For all things with a function, the good resides in their function.

P2: Humans have a function.

P3: (implied): The function of a thing must be that which only it can do.

P4 (implied): Of all the human capacities, rationality is that which only humans can do.

C1: The life of rational activity of the soul is the human function.

P5: To be good means to perform one's function in accordance with the appropriate excellence.

C2: Human good is living a life of rational activity of the soul in accordance with the appropriate excellence.

Being a devout eudaimonist, Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics* was centered on creating a set of guiding principles that people could follow to live a fulfilling life, one marked by *eudaimonia* or happiness. In his teleology, everything "is thought to aim at some good," and, while there are subordinate goods, the hierarchy of goods must culminate in some highest good, which he calls "the chief good" (1094a1, 22). However, for Aristotle, resorting to unhelpful truisms and crudely labeling happiness the chief good is insufficient as people's definitions of happiness differ; while some define it to be wealth and riches, others may define happiness to be honor or contemplation. A more fruitful philosophical venture, then, would be to "first ascertain the function of man" (1.7 1097b23-5). After all, for him, "the good and the 'well' is thought to reside in [its] function" (1.7 1097b23-8). If one can sequentially establish the human function and then the human good, they have necessarily arrived at the definition of happiness because it is the chief good. Although Aristotle posits a valid argument for what the human function and

good are, he fails to adequately address a fundamental tension within his concept of rationality which undermines the persuasive capacity of his judgement.

First and foremost, Aristotle must establish that man has a function. To do so, he affirms the premise through two arguments: an argument from categories and an argument from parts. In his argument from categories, he challenges the notion that categories of men can have functions, while men do not. Using his example about occupations, it seems absurd that “the carpenter...and the tanner [have] certain functions,” while man has none, since carpenters and tanners are both categories of men (1.7 1097b29-30). It would be like saying screwdrivers and hammers have a function, but tools, more broadly, do not. In reality, the function of a tool is one that broadly encompasses the functions of screwdrivers, hammers, and all other tools, and could be something like “facilitating the work of its user” as screwdrivers and hammers each make various tasks easier in their own way. Similarly for humans, the human function must be common and prior to the function of other, more specific categories of man.

In his argument from parts, Aristotle rhetorically questions whether it follows that if “each of the parts evidently has a function,” then the whole “similarly has a function apart from” its parts (1.7 1097b31-2). Examining this question through the example of a house, it becomes clear that the above implication must be true. A house’s constituent parts, like its roof, doors, and walls, all have unique functions in and of themselves (e.g. a roof’s function is to protect the interior from falling objects, a door’s function is to facilitate entry and exit while ensuring security, etc.). Additionally, it seems reasonable to say that, in general, the function of a part is to fulfill some role within the function of the whole, as the aforementioned parts of a house work together to fulfill a house’s role of providing shelter. From this, it follows that the parts of man,

like the “eye, hand, [and] foot” that Aristotle enumerates must work together to fulfill the function of its whole, or the human function (1.7 1097b30-1).

From these two arguments, it follows that man must have a function, and, though not explicitly stated, Aristotle strongly implies that said function must be that which only man can do. In his attempt to pinpoint the human function, Aristotle explicitly rejects the lives of both “nutrition and growth” and “perception,” saying that they are not “peculiar to man” (1.7 1097b33-34). He argues that the life of nutrition and growth is “common even to plants” and that the life of perception is “common even to the horse, the ox, and every animal” (1.7 1098a1-3). By Aristotle’s definition of function, since the ability to grow and have sense perception is not unique to humans, it cannot be their function.

For Aristotle, that which only man can do is lead “an active life of the element that has rational principle” or live a life of rational activity of the soul (1.7 1098a3-4). Here, he spells out his two subdivisions of man’s rational part: that which is “obedient to [a rational principle]” and that which “[possesses a rational principle] and [exercises] thought” (1.7 1098a4-6). Aristotle believes that “life in the sense of activity...seems to be the more proper sense of the term,” which means that the function of man is defined as active reasoning of the soul, not merely passive obedience to reason (1.7 1098a6-8). Thus, having established that man’s function must be that which only it can do and that the life of rational activity of the soul is that which only man can do, it can be concluded that the human function is the life of rational activity of the soul.

As established earlier, Aristotle seeks to use his understanding of the human function as a springboard for his exploration of the human good. To do so, he first establishes that there is a distinction between a “so-and-so and a good so-and-so,” as both “have a function which is in the same kind” but “eminence in respect of excellence [is] added to the function” of that which

qualifies as good (1.7 1098a8-11). For example, while Lang Lang and I are both piano players, the key differentiator is that Lang Lang is a good piano player, playing the piano well and with excellence, while I am more so just blindly banging on the keys. However, here, Aristotle glosses over his definition of a “well performed action,” saying that it must be “performed in accordance with the appropriate excellence” (1.7 1098a14-6). While he states that “appropriate” means “best and most complete” with regards to the human good, he neglects to specify what “best” or “most complete” mean. Though this does not significantly undercut the validity of his argument, it does have some ramifications for its soundness later on.

Using this definition of goodness as excellence in performing one’s function, Aristotle is well equipped to explore what the human good entails. In his own words, the “function of a good man [is] the good and noble performance of [actions of the soul implying a rational principle]” and that the “human good turns out to be the activity of soul in conformity with excellence” (1.7 1098a13-7). Thus, Aristotle concludes that the human good is living a life of rational activity of the soul in accordance with excellence.

However, while supplying his strongly implied premises makes Aristotle’s argument valid, his gaping ambiguity about which rational principle excellence adheres to makes the soundness of his argument dubious. In Aristotle’s philosophy, much like the soul is divided into two parts, so too is the rational principle into theoretical and practical wisdom. He defines theoretical wisdom as “[knowledge of] things that are remarkable, admirable, difficult, and divine,” and “comprehension that grasps the first principles” (6.7 1141b6-7, 6.6 1141a7-8). In contrast, “practical wisdom...is concerned with things human and things about which it is possible to deliberate,” or particulars (6.7 1141b9-16). While theoretical wisdom concerns itself with universal truths and the divine, practical wisdom focuses on deliberating how one should

act in specific situations. Regardless, neither definition is without flaw when substituted into Aristotle's argument.

While Aristotle may initially seem to prefer theoretical wisdom because it is "the best and most complete," this substitution actually conflicts with the uniqueness requirement of being a function. As established earlier, to be the function of a thing is to be that which *only* it can do, yet theoretical wisdom and contemplation is not unique to humans. Rather, it is also definitive of Aristotle's unmoved mover, who spends all of its time thinking about thought and acting on the rational elements that wish to be like it. Similarly to the life of perception being shared by animals and thus making it an invalid human function, the life of rational activity of the soul in accordance with theoretical wisdom is shared by the unmoved mover. Therefore, it would follow that the function of man is actually not what has been established, leading to a contradiction and unraveling Aristotle's entire argument.

However, the chief benefit to choosing theoretical wisdom to define excellence is that it is the highest excellence. As detailed in Book X, "happiness...should be in accordance with the highest excellence" and "the activity of intellect, which is contemplative, seems both to be superior in worth and to aim at no end beyond itself...it follows that this will be the complete happiness of man." (10.7 1177a11, 1177b18-25). In being self-sufficient and complete — the value of contemplation lies in the action itself rather than a further end — theoretical wisdom is more excellent than all other forms of wisdom because no other interacts more closely with the first principles and the divine. On the other hand, excellence in the sense of practical wisdom is clearly worse because, in being so connected to human choice, it is highly unstable and contingent on circumstance. Despite this, it must be noted that practical wisdom is much more distinctly human as it is below the unmoved mover, but beyond the scope of animals and plants

who live lives of perception and growth. Though unresolved, this tension between theoretical and practical wisdom as definitions of excellence points to rich complexity in Aristotle's argument, one that sits at the heart of his ethical philosophy and is not easily reconciled.

Indeed, this irresolvable conflict reflects the complexity of human flourishing, as it was a problem not just for Aristotle, but for other ancient philosophers as well. While his function argument attributes excellence to performing one's function well, it also caps people at being the best human. In contrast, Aristotle's shift to focusing on excellence through contemplation in the later books of the *Nicomachean Ethics* affords people the opportunity to be more than human and strive to be more similar to divine forces like the unmoved mover. Aristotle's provision of excellence as being both practical through the function argument and intellectual through his comments about contemplation purport excellence as a delicate balance between thought and action. Perhaps, the beauty of living a good life lies in its complexity and, in choosing to highlight the push-and-pull between intellectual and practical wisdom, Aristotle leaves the door open for readers to find their own medians.